Chapter 10.

THE ROADS NOT TAKEN

Recalling Leaders, Revisiting History

It is not often that we reflect on what we inherit. But even when we do, there is an inclination to think of the choices made as the only ones possible. Obviously, that cannot always be the case. It is, therefore, useful to regularly revisit the past, especially with regard to strategic assessments. Much of what was long assumed to be the tenets of Indian foreign policy is actually the predilection of the first PM, Jawaharlal Nehru. And this was so because he comprehensively dominated the scene for two decades. But the truth is also that in the early period after Independence, there were vigorous debates even in this domain. A lot of this was driven by his peers, including those who did not share Nehru's ideological bent of mind.

Three relationships, those with Pakistan, China and the US, featured strongly in the argumentation. Overall, Nehru's critics felt that he harboured a sense of false internationalism that came at the cost of national interest. On Pakistan and also on Israel, they believed he was driven by an appeasement that was an important facet of a domestic political strategy. On China, he was perceived by them as displaying misplaced and impractical idealism that ignored the primary logic of statecraft. And where the US was concerned, his views appeared to be an extrapolation of a left-wing antipathy that was so popular in certain circles of the UK. Because these relationships are today the focus of change, it is important for the public to be more familiar with the critical viewpoints. After all, some of the roads not taken then are now being traversed.

Looking back, it is also interesting to note that diverging perspectives were not limited to a narrow group. On the contrary, they ranged from his own deputy Sardar Patel, who passed away early after Independence, to other cabinet colleagues like Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee and Dr B.R.